*cards: center · stretch · top · spread*

# The author decides where a card row's spare height goes

A row of cards gets the whole stage. When the cards are sparse, that height goes somewhere — and only the author knows where.

# Stretch fills the row, and a short card carries the difference.

**What this used to do.**

Every deck rendered card rows this way.

**Right when cards are full.**

A three-line card uses what it gets.

**Wrong when they are sparse.**

A one-line card is as tall as the row.

**Still worth asking for.**

A full grid, or one above a key-insight panel.

# Center shrinks the cards and centers the band.

**The default now.**

Omit the key and you get this.

**Cards fit their text.**

Each line takes what its tallest card needs.

**One gutter.**

Rows stay `gap` apart, matching the columns.

**The cost.**

The band stops short of the stage floor.

# Top anchors the band where the eye enters.

### Under the rule.

Gutter kept · Band centered

Cards start below the headline. Nothing floats.

### Spare height below.

Gutter kept · Band centered

Spare height collects at the bottom.

### Composition void.

Gutter kept · Band centered

Where the content ends is the deck's business.

# Spread shares the height out between the rows.

**Rows move apart.**

Void gone · Gutter kept

The row gap grows; the column gap does not.

**Measured.**

Void gone · Gutter kept

Measured at 4.2x the column gutter.

**Use it deliberately.**

Void gone · Gutter kept

Two sparse rows carry it; a dense grid cannot.

# One token, and every default survives it.

01

**A class sets a variable**

`cards: top` stamps a class that sets `--cards-align`.

02

**Each row keeps its own default**

Each row reads the variable with its own fallback.

03

**So a rule keeps its own default**

`cards: center` stamps nothing; each fallback wins.

04

**And the splitter still wins**

Split pages override it, so a run stays uniform.

*center is the default — every other composition is one line of front matter away.*

# Four values, one default, nothing forced.